among China, Russia, and the United States “resemble a scalene triangle, in which the greatest distance between the three points lies between Moscow and Washington. Chinese-Russia relations are the most positive and stable.” The US–China side of the triangle was, in her estimation then, of an intermediate length.[32] It is quite clear from her essay that this is the configuration that best suits China: US–Russia hostility making Russia dependent on Chinese support, while China deals with the United States on an equal footing on bilateral and global issues. We have seen in recent years that Chinese behaviour is sensitive to even minor changes in the configuration of this triangle. Over the period 2014–16, when Western political and economic sanctions against Russia were at their peak, Russia–China interactions at all official levels clearly reflected the reality of Russia being the junior partner. Over the last two years, with increased Trump–Putin interactions (and notwithstanding the periodical sharp exchanges of rhetoric), the Washington–Moscow side of the triangle may have shortened somewhat, and the Washington–Beijing side has certainly lengthened, with harsh US criticism of Chinese behaviour, the trade war and the US global campaign against Chinese telecom systems. For China, the value of friendship with Russia suddenly became more evident. The normally reticent President Xi Jinping described President Putin as “my best and closest friend” in June 2018 while bestowing on him an Order of Friendship, which seems to have been created for the occasion.[33]

It is difficult to predict any definitive trends in the shape of the US–Russia–China triangle after the world recovers from the ravages of COVID-19 and the United States conducts its presidential elections. Continued US pressure on China, with support from other major powers, may moderate Chinese behaviour in its region and make it more amenable to initiatives to draw it into a cooperative arrangement for a